

say, 582 (out of the theoretically possible 600 in air pistol). The consequence of any shortfall is made up for by a fine. If she shot a 578, Manu would be paying a fine of four Euros. The money was meant for charity.

Closing in on the Olympics, Jaspal progressively raised the stakes. One Euro for every missed point became 10, and then 100. The eventual sum of money was a windfall for some lucky street performers. But the lesson for Manu was priceless.

She'd later credit Jaspal's unusual methodology. "He made the training so difficult for me that this was not very difficult for me when it came to performing. So yeah, definitely he played a huge role in this medal, and definitely it's the sweat and blood of both of us," she would say after the win.

Metamorphosis

Manu, though, has not always been steely-eyed and emotionless. Her equation with Jaspal was not always as trusting. In contrast to the tears of joy she blinked away in Chateauroux, the last time she competed at the Olympics,

she wept in frustration as she competed and failed across three different events.

The Olympics, meant to be the highlight of the then 19-year-old's career, were anything but a nightmare. There was no doubting her prodigious talent; at 16, she became the youngest Indian to win gold at the ISSF shooting World Cup and was soon enough winning World Cups and Commonwealth Games gold medals, almost for fun, and became one of the youngest to qualify for the Tokyo Olympics.

Her impressive results had been achieved while training under Jaspal, a former two-time Olympian and one of the country's top pistol shooters in the 1990s. At the turn of the millennium,

